

the facility of blocking objectionable Web sites, except for MSN Explorer, which allows you to create a Kid Passport wherein access rights can be defined. NetCaptor and Web Hunter Browser once again make use of Internet Explorer to provide you the same, while K-Meleon again lags behind in this feature.

Performance

A majority of the browsers we tested in this category use Internet Explorer’s engine. Hence, their performance was very similar to that of IE. This made them the best performers in the HTML loading test. Opera was the second fastest in the iBench HTML loading test as it rendered all the pages using its own engine (the other browsers were based on either the Netscape or the IE browser engine, which was the fastest). K-Meleon took the maximum time to complete the full test.

K-Meleon also failed to load Caffeine Mark’s Java applet, making it impossible to test the Java performance of this browser. The Internet Explorer based browsers such as NetCaptor and MSN Explorer fared quite well in this test as well.

CONCLUSION

Among the Internet communications suites, had the competition been between IE 6 and Netscape 6, IE would have emerged the winner. However, with **Netscape 6.1**, woes of a crash-prone and slow browser have been effectively dealt with, which makes it the obvious winner in this category. Full of features, and extremely useable and customisable, Netscape 6.1 can get even better if the absurd product activation procedures were eliminated. IE still remains a good choice, but it’s not the best. You have to have it because Windows has it.



Opera 5.12: a good choice for dial-up users



Netscape 6.1: a feature-rich browser

As far as function-specific browsers are concerned, simple, small and functional were the rules for this category, and **Opera** ruled the roost. Opera is the only ‘complete and homogenous’ browser in this category, as it comes with its own HTML rendering engine. The multiple document view has been the favourite of many, but the interface still has room for improvement. Nice bookmarks, customisability, the swiftness and the built-in download manager and pop-up box closer make it highly recommended for dial-up Internet users. NetCaptor 6.5 is also highly functional and something an IE user can easily migrate to, which makes it a great choice for everyday usage.

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